Strengthening She Power

Political and financial empowerment apart, women need safety in homes and outside

By SONALI ACHARJEE

Though *nari shakti* has been a rallying cry for most political parties, empowering women will take more than just empty slogans, populist handouts or symbolic legislation. Especially as women and child safety remains a concern, the country still has a long way to go in terms of maternal and child mortality numbers, or in nutrition. Much has been done, from Integrated Child Development Services to Poshan Abhiyaan, but much more remains to be done too. The two ladies have their work cut out. ■

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

WOMEN'S SAFETY Crimes against women and children continue to be on the rise in India. Hence the need for awareness of support groups, harsher punishments and faster response rates to complaints. Social sensitisation is also a must. Communication that is sexist or discriminatory against any gender or children must be banned, particularly on digital mediums

NUTRITION A third of malnourished children globally are Indian. Experts recommend incorporating more fortified ingredients and enough micronutrients in midday meals

EMPLOYMENT The female labour force participation rate may currently be 37%, but it is not always quality employment. Women also need protection against workplace exploitation



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

ANNAPURNA DEVI, *55* | BJP

Minister of Women & Child Development

↘ **Early life** Devi comes from a Bengali-speaking family in Dumka, Jharkhand

↘ **Political initiation** Content to be a homemaker, she was thrust into political life after her husband Ramesh Yadav, a Rashtriya Janata Dal leader, died in 1998. She quit RJD to join the BJP in 2019 ahead of the Lok Sabha polls

↘ **Sterling achievement** Devi is now one of the two women ministers in the Union cabinet. Her past experience in the area was in 2012, as a cabinet-rank minister for women & child welfare in Jharkhand, along with the irrigation portfolio

Minister of State



SAVITRI THAKUR, *45* | BJP

↘ **Grand entry** Elected from Madhya Pradesh's Dhar SC reserved seat, this is the culmination of a journey that began in 2003 as BJP district panchayat member